

HOW TO WRITE YOUR MOTIVATION LETTER

You may not realize it, but the motivation letter is a very important element in your application dossier: its importance is often under-estimated. Before writing it, **take the time** to have a good look at the study plan (in the menu STUDY) to understand the structure of the program, and read carefully the description of the courses (SUBJECTS in the menu STUDY). You will then be able to relate this information to your academic background, your interests, and your professional aims.

The most important tip is: don't use the models for the motivation letter that you find online. They are very prolix, repetitive, easily identifiable, and they give the impression that you don't have a personal motivation towards the program, which is exactly the opposite of what you need to convey. Remember that you don't have to *impress* us, but rather to convince us - quite a different thing.

Also, the only good thing that ChatGPT and the like can do for you is to correct the grammar once you've written your letter. Don't be tempted by things like "I am fascinated by the intricacies of human language...", or the excellence of our University and the beauty of Italy: we've read that stuff hundreds of times. **Just don't use them.**

The two important rules to write your letter are:

- i) everything that you write should be informative, and
- ii) you should convey a *specific* interest in *this* particular MA

program, not just a generic interest in linguistics or in theoretical philosophy.

Thus, it is useless to put in your letter autobiographical details that are not related to a specific motivation, for instance, that you love learning languages since childhood. On the other hand, if e.g, you are bilingual and you want to study bilingual language acquisition, that is definitely an informative and relevant detail to report.

It is also useless to list in the letter all the wonderful things that you've done - we get that from your CV. Again, report only those experiences that are directly relevant to your motivation, and expand on those. Discuss the way in which this program is connected to your past background and to your objectives for the future. If you just declare an interest in some disciplines of the study plan, this is not informative enough.

It is very important for us that you be fully aware of what you will be studying. We approach the problem of language and cognition with the theoretical and methodological tools of formal disciplines such as logic, formal syntax, computational linguistics. In a nutshell, this means that before doing fancy stuff - say, psycholinguistic experiments - you will have to cope with graphs, formulas, and simple algorithm. It is crucial that you specify whether you are familiar with this type of approach and, if not, why

you think it will be useful for you, so that you are willing to enter a new territory.

We stated that the motivation letter is very important: you may then wonder how we evaluate your dossier.

We have three main criteria: strenght and specificity of the motivation, as expressed in the letter; academic excellence, as evidenced by the BA transcript; congruence of the academic background with the disciplines of our MA program.

We are somewhat flexible on the third criterion: if your background is not fully congruent, but you articulate very well your motivation and you obtained high grades in your BA, you will have good chances. On the other hand, if the motivation letter is badly written, or even copied, this will impact negatively on your application even if your background is congruent and you obtained high grades.

We hope that these tips will be useful for you to write an authentic and well-articulated motivation letter.

On behalf of the L&M Admission Committee:
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